

“O God of Earth and Altar”

Text: G. K. Chesterton, 1906

Meter: 7.6.7.6 D

Suggested Tune: KING’S LYNN

1. O God of earth and altar,
bow down and hear our cry;
our earthly rulers falter,
our people drift and die;
the walls of gold entomb us,
the swords of scorn divide,
take not Thy thunder from us,
but take away our pride.

2. From all that terror teaches,
from lies of tongue and pen,
from all the easy speeches
that comfort cruel men,
from sale and profanation
of honor and the sword,
from sleep and from damnation,
deliver us, good Lord!

3. Tie in a living tether
the prince and priest and thrall,
bind all our lives together,
smite us and save us all;
in ire and exultation
aflame with faith, and free,
lift up a living nation,
a single sword to Thee.

Reflection (Election Day):

This text identifies many of the dangers of modern society and asks God for deliverance from them. The text begins with a direct invocation of God as the God “of earth and altar” – that is, He is the ruler of all that is secular and all that is sacred. We ask God, who is the Lord of all things, to listen to our following troubles. These include: the failure of our civic leaders to

create a just society, the idolatry of wealth that leads to our spiritual “entombment,” the unending violence caused by divisions and rivalries, and, worst of all, our own deaths. We live in a sinful society, but yet, trusting in His mercy, we pray that God will help us fix our sinfulness rather than smiting us altogether, even though we deserve it.

Whereas verse 1 was focused on simply having God listen to our plea, verse 2 notably asks Him to deliver us from our troubles. We ask for deliverance firstly from political lies. These come to us in the forms of fearmongering and false reassurance, both of which are tactics that we know all too well in our world today – political candidates and regimes constantly reshape issues for the sake of either pushing an agenda or hiding an injustice. Next, we ask for deliverance from the monetization of “honor and the sword.” This line denounces those who seek political office as a commodity to enhance their own status. Likewise, it calls out those who commodify violence and murder. How often do our leaders trivialize issues like abortion, the death penalty, euthanasia, and unjust war? Finally, we ask for deliverance from “sleep and from damnation” – from physical death and from eternal spiritual death.

In the final verse, we ask God to look upon us, not simply as individuals, but as a community. We ask to be joined “prince and priest and thrall” – political leaders, spiritual leaders, and commonfolk. We ask that, whatever happens to us, either judgment or salvation, that it be done to all of us. With this mindset, we acknowledge that we are all neighbors and we are responsible for one another’s well-being. That is the only way for our society to advance in a direction that leads us to God.